THE LETTERS OF THE RAMBAM

Don't Call Yourself Ignorant: The Rambam's Letter to Yosef Ibn Jabbar

The Letters of the Rambam (2025)

Source: Igrot HaRambam: the letter to Rabbi Yosef ibn Jabbar of Baghdad (c. 1195; written in Arabic, read in Hebrew translation)

Shiur: Fourth class in the series on the Rambam's letters, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 11 February 2025

These notes are based on the Sofer.ai transcript of the recording. Ibn Jabbar's letter itself has not survived; we know its questions from the reply.

Introduction

So far: the three letters to **Ovadia the convert**, and the two-part **Letter on Astrology**. The longer essays (**Martyrdom**, **Resurrection**) were next, but first some shorter letters "to get a taste": tonight **Ibn Jabbar**, next week **the letter to a dayan**.

Who was Ibn Jabbar?

- **Yosef ibn Jabbar** ("son of Avi al-Khayr") of **Baghdad**: by his own description a **simple Jew**, who could barely read Hebrew and studied the Rambam through his **Arabic Commentary on the Mishnah**.
- Baghdad was home to the **Exilarchate and Geonic establishment**, which didn't like the Rambam's writings, "and the Rambam didn't like them at all either": he criticised them for using communal funds for their lifestyle, and argued with them over halacha.
- Ibn Jabbar **defended the Rambam publicly** and wrote for clarification of what people were saying.

c. 1195, near the end of the Rambam's life, when he was **extremely busy**. Last week's letter ended: "I only wrote because the messenger stood over me." Yet he took the time for this simple man, clearly admiring his **simplicity and idealism**.

The letter mixes **halacha** and **principles of faith**, and ends in an unusually **personal** vein.

(The screen-share failed this week; the Rabbi sent the text as photos to the Tuesday-night WhatsApp group after calling on "Doron, the engineer.")

Part 1: "You Are Not an Am HaAretz"

You call yourself ignorant, but I see from your letter that you are knowledgeable, and that you work hard to understand our **Commentary on the Mishnah**. You don't yet understand the **Mishneh Torah**, written in Hebrew.

Do not belittle yourself or call yourself an *am ha'aretz*. You are our student and beloved to us.

Study in any language

Whoever studies, even **one verse**, and understands it, does well. **It makes no difference whether you learn in Hebrew, Aramaic or Arabic** (today, English or French). What matters is that you **understand**.

If even **Kriat Shema** may be said in any language, "all the more so" Torah study. "Don't feel it's not the real thing."

Never give up

One who doesn't study at all **desecrates God's name**; one who studied once but doesn't keep learning **neglects the mitzvah of Talmud Torah**, equal to all the mitzvot. **Don't despair of reaching perfection.** Many great sages, **Rabbi Akiva** for certain, **started very late.**

Learn enough Hebrew

Learn enough Hebrew to read the Mishneh Torah. It's easy: master **one book** of the fourteen and you'll understand the rest.

The Rambam believed the Mishneh Torah was **accessible to anyone with basic Hebrew**.

I won't translate it into Arabic: its beauty would be lost. In fact I'm having my **Commentary on the Mishnah** and **Sefer HaMitzvot**, written in Arabic, translated **into** Hebrew.

(Elsewhere he says he **regrets** writing them in Arabic.)

May Hashem grant you **the success of both worlds**.

Why both? As Hilchot Teshuvah taught: Hashem gives this world **so that** you can build your share in the next.

Part 2: Resurrection, Again

"This issue of the Rambam supposedly not believing in a physical resurrection really bogged him down for a lot of his career."

What you heard in Baghdad, that I deny resurrection, is **slander**. Whoever says it is either **cunning** (they know I didn't mean it and want to defame me) or **a fool** who **confuses Olam HaBa with Techiyat HaMetim.**

As learned in Hilchot Teshuvah: **for many Rishonim they're the same**, resurrection ushers in a new, physical world to come. **For the Rambam they're separate**: Olam HaBa is spiritual and exists **now**; resurrection is physical. His full **Essay on Resurrection** will reach you.

"There is a major problem with the Rambam's conception of resurrection in the whole scheme of things. I don't have an adequate answer. We'll see it when we learn the Essay on Resurrection."

Part 3: Milah Comes from Moshe, Not Avraham

The charge: the Rambam wrote that **all** mitzvot, even those given before Sinai, bind us **through Moshe**. So we circumcise **because Moshe commanded it**, not because of Avraham. The Baghdad rabbis objected: the word **ברית** appears **13 times** in the milah passage in Lech Lecha (the Rambam himself lists them in the Mishneh Torah), and the Gemara speaks of **13 covenants** made over milah.

The Rambam: "I'm 100% right."

the Gemara (Chullin) says it was **forbidden at Sinai** but **written in its place** (Vayishlach) :**גיד הנשה**
.where the story happened. Its **authority** is Moshe's

Ask these blind people who compete with the sighted: the verses in Lech Lecha about the covenant: **who wrote them?** Did Avraham say them and Moshe **copy** them, "the way plagiarists do"? Or did **Hashem tell Moshe**? Obviously the latter, and whoever denies it denies **that the whole Torah was given to Moshe**. How would we even know what Hashem told Avraham, except through Moshe?

Those who don't see this have spent their lives on **secondary matters, not principles**. Everything in the Torah, including what preceded his prophecy (the **Noahide laws**, **Avraham's milah**), **we keep only because Moshe commanded it at Sinai.**

Why it matters

The Rambam writes elsewhere that one prophet's words can, in principle, be **superseded by a greater later prophet**. Only **Moshe** can never be superseded, since one of the 13 Principles is that **he was the greatest prophet**. If a mitzvah's authority came from Avraham, someone could claim a later, greater prophet had overridden it. **Every word of the Torah, stories included, comes from Moshe at Sinai.**

Part 4: Sailing on Shabbat

The charge: the Rambam permitted travelling **by ship on Shabbat**, if you boarded **before Shabbat**.

"Yes, I said it," and the **Rosh Yeshivah of Baghdad** (Shmuel ben Eli) "never understood my position." He refers Ibn Jabbar to two earlier letters on it.

Techum Shabbat	Outside a city you may go only **2,000 amot** (roughly 1,000m)
The Rambam	**No techum above 10 tefachim** (about 80cm). If there are 10 tefachim of water between the hull and the seabed, the ship may sail on
The Gemara's doubt	The Gemara is **unsure** whether techum applies above 10 tefachim. The Rambam: that doubt concerns **land**, which could be a public domain. The sea is at most a **karmelit**, a lesser domain, where there is no doubt
If unsure of the depth	Techum is **rabbinic**, so **ספק דרבנן לקולא**: be lenient. Only if you **know** it's shallower may you not go beyond 2,000 amot

This became the accepted ruling of later poskim.

A principle about strictness

If the Baghdad rabbis **know it's permitted** but chose to be strict and made it the city's custom, **you must keep it there**. A custom accepted knowingly has the force of a **communal vow** (that's where *minhag* comes from). But if they **thought it was forbidden**, it's a **mistaken custom** and needn't be kept, and you should **teach them** they're wrong.

Part 5: Niddah: Strictness vs. Karaism

The Torah says things a *niddah* touches become impure, and **ורחץ במים**, "he shall wash in water."

- **The Karaites** read that as **a wash** in the evening, a huge leniency (no mikveh), with a huge stringency: a *niddah* may not **touch** food, clothes or things in the house.
- Some Rabbinite communities adopted the stringency too: wives told not to cook or touch things. ("I suppose some women would like that: half the month they don't have to do anything in the kitchen!")

The Rambam:

- **Distinguish *assur/mutar* from *tamei/tahor*.** What is forbidden is relations and affection during *niddah* and the seven clean days. **Ritual impurity of objects doesn't apply today.**

- If someone wants to avoid her touching things **as an extra stringency**, fine.

- **But** in Egypt those communities often **didn't keep the clean days or use the mikveh**, relying on a wash, so the Rambam **placed a *cherem* on those who don't go to the mikveh.**

But one who keeps that stringency **thinking the Torah requires it** has left the House of the Rabbis and become **an unbeliever in the Oral Torah**: a Karaite.

"You can be as strict as you want in life, as long as you recognise it's a *chumra*."

The Mars bar

A true story: a student at a London school was eating a Mars bar, not *chalav Yisrael*. His teacher said: **"Why are you eating chazir?"** The boy concluded they were the same, and in later life ate *treif*: "for him it was the same thing." **Torah prohibitions, rabbinic ones, and stringencies are different levels**, and must be taught as such.

Part 6: Shorter Rulings

Topic	The Rambam
Verses embroidered on tzitzit / tallit	**Forbidden.** A tallit has **no inherent holiness** (it isn't *tashmish kedushah* like tefillin or a Sefer Torah; strictly it may be thrown away, and you may even enter a bathroom in it, though we take it off). So verses with Hashem's name would be disgraced. **Cut them out** and put them in *genizah*
Accepting a voluntary fast	Accept it the **afternoon before**, **at the end of Minchah** (at *Elokai Netzor*). The Mishneh Torah first had it **inside** the Amidah (in *Shema Koleinu*); he found in the **Yerushalmi** that it belongs **after**, and the current text is corrected. (The **Chida** wrote a prayer to insert in *Shema Koleinu*; the Rambam prefers no interruption.) The **six** public fasts need no acceptance
Extra *aravot* in the arba minim	**Don't add them.** Adding **hadassim** for beauty is fine (mentioned in the Talmud; in Hilchot Lulav he even praises it)
A *ba'al keri* on Yom Kippur night	Ezra's decree requiring immersion before prayer or study **was annulled**. So **don't go to the mikveh on Yom Kippur** (washing is forbidden). Some Baghdad sages permitted it, like washing off dirt, and the **Ben Ish Chai** (*Rav Pe'alim*) allows it if it disturbs one's concentration; we don't follow that
Kedushah praying alone	The Mishneh Torah says **skip** the *Kadosh kadosh* in the blessings before Shema when alone. Here he **retracts**: that's not our *own* sanctification (as in **נקדישך** in the Amidah, which needs a minyan) but a **description** of what the angels say, so **say it**. He never fixed the Mishneh Torah, but his son **Rabbeinu Avraham** confirmed it was his final view

Olam HaBa: don't worry about the details

You asked what the World to Come is. I've written what can be said. **My advice: don't delve too deeply.** Even great scholars struggle to grasp a soul without a body, and some deny it. **All the more so a beginner** like you.

It won't harm your faith if, for now, you think the people of Olam HaBa have bodies, even that they eat, drink and have children in the upper heavens or Gan Eden, as many say. People believe far more foolish things without harming their core faith.

"This is remarkable," for two reasons:

1. In **Hilchot Teshuvah** he called that belief the view of "the foolish Arabs."

2. Believing **God** is corporeal is **heresy** (the 13 Principles).

The distinction: principles vs. their details. *That* there is an Olam HaBa is a **principle**. *That it is purely spiritual* is a **detail**: important to know one day, but if it's too hard now, a physical picture won't destroy you. Believing **Hashem** has a body *does* destroy you: that is a principle.

That's why we don't teach children the Rambam's spiritual Olam HaBa. "I can't tell you how many times people have asked me: **will I see my wife again? my mother, my father?** Nobody knows. Anyone who tells you they know doesn't." But if it helps someone believe in Olam HaBa, "it's not the end of the world."

Part 7: "Leave Them Alone"

Everything you wrote of your **love for me** will bring you great reward, because it is **love for the sake of Heaven**, drawn from my words of Torah, which are Hashem's. We must love Hashem with all our heart, and that includes His Torah and those who teach it.

I hear, true or not, that **someone speaks ill of me**, seeking to **raise himself through my disgrace**, going beyond proper criticism of my book. (He doesn't name him, "but I don't think it's hard to guess.") **And I hear that you have stood up against them a little.**

Don't do it. We **forgive** whoever does it out of **foolishness**, and also whoever does it **for some benefit**.

It doesn't harm me, and it benefits him, so stopping him would be **the trait of Sedom** (*zeh neheneh vezeh lo chaser*). He gains: when he finds fault with someone well known, especially in religious matters, he looks wise and knowledgeable, and his honour rises in people's eyes. **And it benefits me too, in this world and the next.**

- **The next:** whoever hears himself insulted and doesn't respond is rewarded.

- **This world: כל מי שמבקש להעלים מה שגילה השם, אמנם מוסיף לו גילוי**: whoever tries to suppress what Hashem has revealed only **reveals it more**.

"If only people nowadays understood this." Every year another **book ban**: "we've read this book and it's heresy." The result? **Sales go up.** People are curious.

Don't bring trouble on yourself. I need no man's help. **Let everyone do as he wishes.**

"How magnanimous. He knows he's right, and doesn't care what people are saying."

Summary

1. **Don't call yourself ignorant.** Torah in **any language** you understand; **never give up**; late starters like **Rabbi Akiva** became great. Learn enough Hebrew for the Mishneh Torah. He refused to translate it into Arabic.
2. He **affirms physical resurrection**; critics are cunning or confuse it with Olam HaBa.
3. **Every mitzvah binds us through Moshe**, even milah and the Noahide laws. Moshe alone can never be superseded.
4. **Sailing on Shabbat** is permitted above 10 tefachim. A **knowingly** stricter custom binds like a vow; a **mistaken** one doesn't.
5. **Niddah**: stringency is fine; **thinking it's Torah law** is Karaism. The Mars bar.
6. **No verses on tzitzit**; accept a fast **after** Minchah; no extra aravot; no mikveh on Yom Kippur; **say Kedushah of Yotzer alone** (his final view).
7. **Principles vs. details**: a beginner may picture Olam HaBa physically for now; never God.
8. **Don't defend me.** Critics gain honour, I gain reward, and suppression only spreads the book.

Coming Up

Next week, 8pm: the Rambam's **letter to a dayan**, in one session; then the longer essays: **Kiddush Hashem (martyrdom)** and **Resurrection**.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/qWfj4sIpJHc · More shiurim: rabbikada.com